

T. Ben Baker, PhD, JD

Assistant Professor, Colby College, Department of Philosophy

tbbaker@colby.edu | tbenbaker.com | ORCID: 0000-0003-0027-1372 | [Google Scholar](#)

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

- **Colby College, Assistant Professor** 2023–present
Waterville, ME
– Department of Philosophy, Davis AI Institute
- **University of Pennsylvania, Provost Postdoctoral Fellow** 2020–2023
Philadelphia, PA
– Kording lab, Departments of Bioengineering and Neuroscience

EDUCATION

- **University of Pennsylvania, PhD Philosophy** 2020
Philadelphia, PA
– Dissertation: “Cognition in Nature: Information, Explanation, Embodiment”
– Social, Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience, Graduate Certificate
– Dean’s award for distinguished teaching by a graduate student
- **Yale Law School, JD** 2014
New Haven, CT
– Substantial Analytic Writing on Mens Rea and Manslaughter
– Lowenstein International Human Rights Clinic
- **Brown University, BA (Concentrations in Philosophy (honors) and Economics)** 2010
Providence, RI

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Articles & Book Chapters

- **Use and Usability: Concepts of Representation** [link] 2026
with R Lange, A Richmond, A Achille, R Cao, N Kriegeskorte, O Schwartz, X Pitkow, Neurons, Behavior, Data Analysis, and Theory
- **Rethinking Artificial General Intelligence: Beyond Anthropomorphism** 2026
Invited book chapter, Introducing Philosophy of Mind, Today (eds. D Curry, L Daoust), Routledge
- **Understanding Complexity Through Affordances** [link] 2025
with Sonia Roberts, Minds and Machines
- **Computational Kinematics of Dance: Distinguishing Hip Hop Genres** [link] 2024
with T Liu, J Matelsky, F Parodi, J Krakauer, K Kording, Frontiers in Human Robotics and AI
- **Three Aspects of Representation in Neuroscience** [link] 2022
with B Lansdell and K Körding, Trends in Cognitive Sciences
- **Creativity in AI-Dance Art** [link] 2022
Proceedings of the International Conference on Computational Creativity
- **Natural Information, Factivity, and Nomicity** [link] 2021
Biology & Philosophy
- **Referee Report of (hypothetical) Philosophy101 Textbook** [link] 2021
Teaching Philosophy
– Spanish translation by Fredy H.P. Galindo, 2023, *Cuestiones Filosofía*

Public Writing & Reports

- **Commentary on Favela and Machery** [\[link\]](#) 2023
Symposium contribution, The Brains Blog
- **The Time is Ripe to Reverse Engineer an Entire Nervous System** [\[link\]](#) 2023
Position paper, Alliance for C. elegans Neural Dynamics (ACeND)
- **What Does Engaged Philosophy Look Like?** [\[link\]](#) 2016
with L Daoust and R Willison, guest post, DailyNous.com
- **Before Their Time: Challenges to the Prohibition Against Child Marriage in Sierra Leone** [\[link\]](#) 2013
with A Elbogen, S Keene, Allard K. Lowenstein International Human Rights Clinic

TEACHING

Instructor of record for 19 semester-courses (250+ Colby students through Spring 2026). Mean instructor rating 4.45/5 across evaluated sections. Frequency in parentheses where > 1.

Courses

- **Colby College, Assistant Professor, Department of Philosophy** 2023–present
Waterville, ME
 - All courses developed and first-taught by me
 - Central Philosophical Issues: Mind, Body & Machine (×6)
 - Philosophy of Dance (×2)
 - AI and Human Values
 - Philosophy of Emotion
 - Philosophy of Cognitive Science
 - Philosophy of Science
 - Bodies and Power
- **University of Pennsylvania, Instructor of Record, Department of Philosophy** 2018–2020
Philadelphia, PA
 - Introduction to Philosophy (×2)
 - Philosophy and Visual Perception
 - Ethics

Student Advising

- **Honors theses:** 1 in Philosophy; 1 in Computer Science (cross-departmental)
- **Senior independent studies:** 2 in Philosophy
- **January-term and summer mentees:** 4 students

SELECTED TALKS

Invited Talks

- **What Does It Mean to Be Human?** 2025
Invited all-school speech, Loomis Chaffee School, Windsor CT
- **Rethinking Artificial General Intelligence** 2025
Oberlin Colloquium in Philosophy, Oberlin College
- **Invited Commentator, Symposium on Technology and Cognition** 2025
Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology, annual meeting
- **Moving Between Genres: A Computational and Embodied Exploration of Dance** 2025
Invited contributor, Slippage: 3D Humanities Series, Northwestern University
- **Dance Machines!** 2024
James Madison University, sponsored by the Philosophy & Religion Department and JMU Dance Program
- **Six Forms of Dance Cognition** 2023
Mind the Body, University of Utah

Conference Presentations & Panels

- **So You Think AI Can Dance?** 2022
Eye, Mind, and Image: Themes from Visual Studies, UPenn
- **Panelist, Symposium on Affirming Black Excellence in Neuroscience** 2021
Cognitive Neuroscience Society (virtual)
- **Representation in Neuroscience** 2020
Neuromatch Conference 3.0 (virtual)
- **The Factivity and Nomicity of Information** 2019
Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology, Cincinnati OH
- **Neural Dynamics and Inner Representations** 2017
Conference on Representing Reality, SUNY Potsdam
- **Learning to Dance with Dynamic Systems** 2017
Graduate BEN Talks, UPenn (internal)
- **Weakness of Will in Desire-First Accounts of Rational Action** 2015
Philosophers' Cocoon Conference, Tampa FL

SCIENTIFIC COLLABORATIONS

- **Computational Kinematics of Human Movement: Motion Capture & Data Collection (Kinelab)** 2024–present
Colby College
 - Designed and built a markerless motion-capture system at Colby; data collection ongoing in collaboration with Veronica Romero (Colby Psychology) under a joint umbrella IRB
- **Computational Kinematics of Human Movement: Movement Modeling (KineTrace)** 2025–present
Colby College
 - Developing self-supervised next-window-prediction models trained on a custom biomechanical featurization of human movement (precursor: *Frontiers* 2024); early-stage collaboration with Amy Laviers (Robotics, Automation, and Dance Lab, Germantown PA)
- **Use and Usability: Concepts of Representation** 2022–2026
CCN Generative Adversarial Collaboration
 - Collaborative project examining representation across Philosophy, Neuroscience, Cognitive Science, and Computer Science, with Richard D. Lange, Andrew Richmond, Odelia Schwartz, Alessandro Achille, Xaq Pitkow, Rosa Cao, Nikolaus Kriegeskorte
- **Alliance for *C. elegans* Neural Dynamics (ACeND)** 2024–2025
Project Member, Colby College
 - Contributing theoretical insights for an interdisciplinary, nationwide consortium working towards simulating *C. elegans* from molecules to behavior

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & LEADERSHIP

- **Departmental/College Service, Colby College** 2023–present
 - **Department of Philosophy** (2023–present): Clark Award and Pepper Prize judging (reading and scoring senior essays, coordinating prize text, presenting at the awards banquet); co-organizing the annual Philosophy Department Awards Banquet; reviewing honors-thesis proposals for the Honors Program
 - **Faculty Advisory Committee, Davis Institute for Artificial Intelligence** (2023–present): Planning around Colby's AI policies and tools, event organization
 - **Search Committees** (2023–2026): three for hires in Philosophy (one TT, two VAP); one for the Director of the Davis AI Institute; one as external reviewer for Psychology
 - **Lunder Institute for American Art, Faculty Advisory Group** (2024–2025): Planning and participating in initiatives around integrating museum resources and visiting fellows into the work and teaching of Colby faculty, handling internal grant funding
 - **Science Technology and Society Faculty Advisory Board** (2023–2025): Contributing to initiatives for the STS department around student participation, course options, and internal funding
 - **Reuman Reading Group Organizer** (2024–2025): communications, documentation, and publicity for Colby's 27-year-running faculty-student reading group in philosophy

• **Conference/Event Organization,**

2018–present

- **Philosophy Symposium** (Spring 2025, *Colby*): Organized annual public lecture on Ethics of Social AI, with student participation, sponsored by the Philosophy department and the Davis AI institute.
- **The Flavor Continues Residency Organizer** (2024, *Colby*): Coordinated residency for a Boston-based Hip Hop non-profit, offering community workshops, guest teaching in Colby dance classes, and a performance
- **Birge Lecture Co-organizer** (Fall 2023, *Colby*): Helped select speaker and support publicity for Colby’s annual Kingsley Birge Memorial Lecture in Sociology
- **Philosophy and Engagement Conference Co-organizer** (2019, *UPenn*): Collaborated on planning and executing an interdisciplinary conference exploring the intersection of philosophy and community engagement
- **Indian Philosophy Reading Group** (2019, *UPenn*): Managed communications around logistics and selecting readings for graduate student discussion group
- **Admitted Student Weekend Coordinator** (2018, *UPenn*): Organized accommodations, planned activities, and facilitated interactions between faculty and prospective graduate students during recruitment weekend

• **Peer Review,**

ongoing

- **Journal reviewer:** *Philosophical Psychology*; *Philosophy of Science*; *IEEE Robotics and Automation Magazine*; *Dance Research Journal*